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Female Vengeance in Antiquity: An Analysis of Euripides' and Seneca's *Medea*

Medea is one of the strongest female characters in Greek and Roman myth. Her backstory is depicted in Apollonius of Rhodes' *Argonautica* as the daughter of King Aeetes of Colchis who is hit by Eros' arrow, as a result of the intervention of Hera and Aphrodite. This caused Medea to fall in love with Jason and aid him in retrieving the Golden Fleece in return for taking her away from Colchis with him. She betrayed her family by doing this and caused the death of her brother and eventually King Pelias of Iolcus, who had sent Jason on the seemingly impossible task of retrieving the Golden Fleece. What transpired between these two lovers afterwards was explored by one of the three great tragedians of Ancient Greece, Euripides, and by the famous Roman tragedian, Seneca. This essay will analyze the portrayal of Medea by the tragedians Euripides and Seneca and how they illustrated the awakening of female wrath by the restrictive nature of their societies.

While Euripides wrote his play first, Seneca added more depth to the character of Medea which in turn created a bolder version of an already well-known figure. Seneca and Euripides both made use of the standards their societies had set when it came to women. Males had all the fun and females rarely had any because in men's eyes, women were flowers who might wither if they are allowed out of their glass case. For example, tragedies from antiquity rarely had a female as the lead character although it

is still disappointing that the role of Medea was played by a male rather than a woman but that is how the world worked hundreds of years ago. And not to mention, these two plays were also written by males, however, it was a start for the world of tragedy and allowed a cultural experience to exhibit the female psyche to the public. Medea, unlike many women, appeared to be educated which is noticeable by her proper use of rhetoric. She had a bright mind and learned witchcraft but fell in love with the wrong man. Seneca and Euripides had many contrasts in their delivery of Medea and her intent. While Euripides illustrated Medea as a victim wailing over her frustrations and the unfairness of her situation, Seneca made her frustration into something more malicious. Stephen Ohlander, the author of *Dramatic Suspense in Euripides' and Seneca's Medea*, makes a great point when he gives "credit to the Greek poet, whose heroine is assured of our sympathies, while withholding it from Seneca's, who wins none of the same" (284) because it illustrates where that gap is between the two Medea's via the audience's reaction. Both of these tragedians play off of her representation as a barbarian from the Greek perspective and according to male-dominated societies, the feminine mind is not made for violence as it is a barbarian trait. Euripides and Seneca ignored this stigma their society had created as a norm and let Medea's passionate vengeance thrive instead.

Euripides' version of Medea was more human but with a trickster nature who used persuasive words to woo the sympathy of others in order to get what she wanted without large suspicion. Her role as a wife within Greek society was one of obedience to the will of her husband and as the Nurse opens the prologue, she says, "[w]hen [Medea]

first arrived...the local folk loved her. They saw in her a perfect wife for Jason...She never argued with Jason. Always compromising, always accommodating –and that, you see, is how a woman earns her security: never argu[ing] with your husband!” (Euripides, 13-14). Medea, the Nurse and the Chorus of Corinthian women appeared to be the only people aware of any injustice done to her. The only exception was Aegeus who pitied her situation. He was the only male not caught up in the ridiculous notion that men can do no wrong. Euripides uses the Nurse to recall the events which led to the current day and explains how “now there’s nothing but arguing, nothing but hatred, nothing but poison, nothing but - Jason betrayed his children and his wife, married the Princess...Meanwhile, my mistress...the Fates fully against her and feeling totally dejected, screams and cries out at him, asking him to remember his promises to her-” (Euripides, 15-17). Medea is now not only a foreigner in Greece but also publicly shamed when she is tossed aside like a torn and bloodied shirt that Jason no longer has the desire to wear. From anyone’s point of view, Medea’s need for justice after this embarrassment is expected. And to add fuel to the fire, Jason’s new father-in-law, King Creon of Corinth, decides to exile Medea along with her children. But, she exploits his pity and begs him to “[h]ave pity on them...You, too are a father and surely you’ll sympathise-” (Euripides, 349) so that she can have time to plan and enact her revenge against Glauce, Jason’s new wife, and Creon. Euripides has the men suspecting she is up to no good since “[i]f women are...deadly for men, it all goes back to Pandora-” (McAuslan, 94) and as most people know, when Pandora opened the jar given to her by Zeus she let out all evils into the world and men began to scorn women for the mistake

of one. Within Greek society, women were underestimated and expected to conform to the decisions of males since, as seen with Pandora, they cannot make good choices on their own. Medea ended up benefiting from this ignorance as the Nurse was the first person to realize Medea was so unhappy that she might murder her own children. Medea was thought of as a mistake that could be fixed by throwing her away but she ended up being very resourceful and used her powers to her advantage when she bargained for sanctuary with Aegeus by promising that he could one day have children, all with the help of a magic potion of hers. Not only that but she convinced Glauce to take a poisoned cloak and crown from Medea and Jason's two sons and killed both Glauce and Creon via these two objects. Although all of this sounds horrible, Euripides' Medea held more compassion than Seneca's as seen when she was torn between saving her sons out of love or killing them so that they would not "be killed by [her] enemies. And killed they will surely be-" (Euripides, 1070-1071). Euripides' portrayal of Medea was that of a scorned human woman who demanded justice for her tears and not the crazed creature with a desire to exact revenge that we see in Seneca.

Seneca's portrayal of Medea is that of an impervious woman with no heart and with no morality left. She absolutely loathes Jason for marrying another woman and thinks him weak as he only betrayed her in order to keep their children safe which apparently was unnecessary but he had to as he was being pressured by two opposing forces demanding her exile for her past crimes. *Women in Antiquity* touched on how "women need courage and endurance as much as men do; men should have as high as standard of sexual virtue as women-" (51) and Medea probably thought in the same way

as she “let weightier rage swell up...[so her] crimes ought to increase-” (Seneca, 49-50). The Nurse later describes “[h]ow great her bitterness is growing! Now it fires itself...[b]ut horrors, greater horrors, Medea plans-” (Seneca, 671-684). Seneca’s Medea is only wearing the shell of a human and is now closer to divine with her malicious powers. She makes Euripides’ Medea look benevolent in comparison. He does not introduce her softly but fiercely and aggressively and allows her to become a more active character than Euripides. Medea is most certainly the villain of her own story and Jason looks like the victim especially when she murders one of his sons and tells him that “this one will die the same, but you will watch” (Seneca, 1000) and has no mercy on her own children. This Medea wants to see her enemies in pain and anguish and has no desire for honour or glory. Euripides’ Jason was a foolish Greek man who thought that women are emotional creatures and change how they feel often as many Greek men did. He never questioned that Medea may be tricking him when she changed her attitude so quickly. In Lefkowitz and Fant’s book, *Women’s Life in Greece and Rome*, they mention how in the conditions for the dissolution of marriage in Rome that “whatever is done or said in the heat of anger is not valid, unless the determination become apparent by the parties persevering in their intention-” (115) which may explain why nobody attempted to stop Medea until after she killed Creon and Glauce. Seneca allowed Medea’s feminine wrath to open up her hatred and fuel her actions in the most devastating and cruel ways. Her acceptance of herself is morbidly captivating where she says, “[n]ow, I am Medea. My nature has grown with my suffering. I am happy that I ripped my brother’s head away, I am glad I sliced his limbs, and glad I stripped my father of his ancestral

treasure, I am glad I set on the daughters to murder the old man-" (Seneca, 909-916).

Seneca managed to create so much hatred in his tragedy but did it in a way that leaves his audience immobilized by the pure and raw emotions. It leaves a person questioning how awful it must have been to be a woman in ancient times if this is the result of years of feeling undervalued and neglected.

Euripides and Seneca wanted to show their audience two very different sides of the same woman. They followed their individual ideas of justice and retribution and although the plays are similar in plot, they cannot be said to be the same. Both tragedians lived in societies which offered little freedom to women in relation to their husbands, or in Medea's case her ex-husband. While these tragedies are equally powerful, they each have their own separate agenda. Euripides showed the biased path unwelcomed women were forced to go down, and inspired his audience to sympathize with issues surrounding females in their society. Seneca allowed Medea to thrive in her true nature and become not a simple woman but a dangerous goddess which in turn led this beautiful dragon of a woman to accept her imperfections and rise to fulfill her long unsatiated thirst. Unfair treatment was avenged in both tragedies and the feminine nature was finally allowed to transform into brilliant justice.

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